

### Critical Lab Values: Potassium (K<sup>+</sup>)

Potassium is the primary intracellular cation, essential for maintaining electrical excitability in cardiac

Normal Range:

The normal serum potassium level is 3.5 to 5.0 mEq/L.

Clinical Implications:

1. Hypokalemia (potassium < 3.5 mEq/L) can cause muscle weakness, cardiac dysrhythmias (U wave)
2. Hyperkalemia (potassium > 5.0 mEq/L) can cause muscle twitching, flaccid paralysis, and life-threatening